Consommé regularly has some garnish or herb to lend interest, but it is the quality and clarity of the soup itself that is at its heart.

chicken consommé

SERVES 4 **PREP TIME** 15 MINS PLUS CHILLING **COOK** 1 HR 20 MINS **FREEZE** NOT SUITABLE

2 large egg whites
1 tbsp passata or 1 tsp tomato purée
1 chicken leg, boned and minced or finely chopped
1 onion, chopped
1 carrot, chopped
1 leek, chopped
1 garlic clove, chopped
1 tbsp chopped parsley
2 quarts (2 liters) cold chicken stock
salt and freshly ground pepper
chervil, to garnish

1 To make the clarification mixture, whisk the egg whites just enough to loosen them and form a few bubbles. Add the passata or tomato purée and mix thoroughly.

2 Place the chicken, vegetables, garlic, and parsley in a bowl, add the egg white mixture, and mix thoroughly—use an electric mixer with paddle attachment if need be. Refrigerate until well chilled.

3 Combine the stock with the clarification mixture in a deep, narrow saucepan. Heat slowly, uncovered, until the stock comes to a boil. Gently stir to keep the egg from sticking. Once the stock reaches boiling point, turn the heat down immediately and let simmer gently for at least an hour, or until a white crust forms. When it is hard, poke a hole through it to check on the clarity.

4 When the consommé is clear and the clarification ingredients cooked, widen the hole and strain the consommé through a muslin-lined sieve into a clean container. Season with salt and pepper, garnish with chervil, and serve.